Pandavas, is said to have been situated in Delhi along the banks of the Yamuna. According to a strong tradition, its site was under the sixteenth-century fortress of Purana Qila (literally Old Fort). The tradition was given credence by the fact that a village called Indrapat used to occupy the mound. Archaeological excavations inside the fort have revealed a significant Late Iron Age settlement that continued to be occupied till the Gupta period. There is a small museum in Purana Qila that shows photographs and artifacts from the excavations. However, it is impossible to prove if this was indeed the city mentioned in the epic. Nothing has been found so far that obviously matches the descriptions of Indraprastha—no palace or audience hall that would have attracted the envy of the Kauravas. Perhaps the remains lie hidden under a later building or perhaps they were swept away by a flood on the Yamuna. It is impossible to say. Nonetheless, we can see that Delhi was an important settlement for many centuries. An Ashokan rock inscription was found near the Kalkaji temple in 1996, suggesting that Delhi may have included several habitations in addition to that at Purana Qila.

The first Delhi of which we have definite historical knowledge was built by the Tomar Rajputs, who made it their headquarters in the eighth century. Their first settlement was at Suraj Kund in the extreme south of Delhi. Then, as now, the water supply was a major concern, and a large stone dam built by the Tomars still stands. The nearby village of Anangpur recalls the name of Raja Anang Pal. A stream from the dam feeds a stepped tank that was probably linked to a temple dedicated to the Sun God—hence the name Suraj Kund (Pool of the Sun). Unfortunately, the lake is often dry now because urbanization and illegal quarrying have disrupted the water-catchment.

In the eleventh century, the Tomars moved to a more defensible position farther west and constructed a large fort—Lal Kot, meaning Red Fort. Thus, Shah Jehan’s seventeenth-century Red Fort was not the first to bear that name. To mark his place in history, Anang Pal also added his name to the Iron Pillar.